There are two facets to Chief Justice Chandrachud's evolving personality as he demonstrated in his tenure so far. One is jurisprudential, the core for any judge. But the other, the internal administrative realm, is no less vital—and he draws a direct link between the two. The CJI believes that the notorious tardiness of the Indian judicial system—where the process itself is said to be the punishment—is a great deterrent to justice. The Supreme Court's case load and pendency clinch this: he inherited nearly 70,000 pending cases. To cut down the mountain, Chandrachud laid down norms about listing of cases and mentioning by lawyers. By the end of 2023, the top court had decided on 29,337 cases as against 24,825 newly registered cases, showing a higher rate of disposal. At the CJI's initiative, the SC has now been linked to the National Judicial Data Grid, a repository of data relating to pendency of cases and disposal rate of courts across India. The move even earned praise from Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

In court, the CJI played by the book, focusing on nuances and ignoring public narratives in a variety of cases: the Hindenburg-Adani affair, the Maharashtra trust vote, the administrative power tussle in Delhi. When the horrific video from Manipur went viral, the SC took suo motu cognisance. And while a 3:2 majority verdict in October ruled against granting constitutional validity to same-sex marriages, Chandrachud and Justice Sanjay Kishan Kaul, in minority views, made persuasive arguments for more empathetic legal frameworks.

A strong votary of constitutional morality, the CJI expedited the setting up of constitutional benches to hear matters of national importance. On the second day of 2023, a constitution bench delivered a significant judgement, upholding the legality of the Centre's 2016 demonetisation. Today, several constitution benches are hearing politically sensitive cases, such as the Centre's use of the money bill route to pass key legislations and the issue of electoral bonds. Chandrachud has often taken the lonely path, even at the risk of inconveniencing the Centre. That sense of a mutually restrictive duality came through early in 2023, when Vice President and Rajya Sabha chairman Jagdeep Dhankhar said Parliament was the "north star" of democracy. This was perceived as a response to Chandrachud's statement at a seminar, calling the basic structure doctrine of the Constitution a "north star" that gives direction to its interpreters and implementers.



Several Opposition leaders believe the CJI has been conservative in taking on the government on key political and institutional issues. "He has been quick in upholding individual liberty but avoids direct confrontation with the Centre," says a Congress MP

The bigger debate with the political class related to judges' appointments. In January, the SC collegium headed by Chandrachud reiterated its proposal to appoint advocate Saurabh Kirpal as a judge of the Delhi High Court, rejecting objections